YOUR MONEY PERSONALITY

# The Overthinker

## A considered, cautious relationship with money. And the cost of it.

More research, more comparison, never quite ready.



Peter Komolafe
FOUNDER, CALM MONEY

PART ONE · DO YOU RECOGNISE YOURSELF?

# Before we go any further, read these five statements.

If you recognise yourself in three or more of them, this guide is about you. Not someone like you. You.

- ○ I understand a lot about personal finance but have not done much about it.
- ○ I have started to set up pensions, investments, or savings plans several times without completing.
- ○ I worry about making a financial decision I cannot reverse or recover from.
- ○ When I face a financial choice I tend to research it extensively and still feel uncertain.
- ○ I know what I should be doing. I just cannot seem to start.

The rest of this guide is an honest reading of what this pattern tends to mean, why it tends to happen, what it tends to cost, and what you can actually do about it.

PART TWO · IDENTITY

# The Overthinker, honestly.

THE PATTERN

You are not disengaged from your finances. You think about money a great deal. The problem is that thinking has become a substitute for doing. You have read the books, listened to the podcasts, and visited the comparison sites. You have a clear general sense of what good financial behaviour looks like. What you have not done is apply it to your own situation, commit to a decision, and move.

This is not a character flaw. It is a specific cognitive pattern: intolerance of uncertainty combined with choice overload. The financial world offers an overwhelming number of options at every decision point, and your brain, which is wired to find the optimal choice before committing, experiences this as a reason to keep researching rather than a reason to start anywhere. The outcome is that you remain financially inactive while being financially literate.

> *I know exactly how a Stocks and Shares ISA works. I know about global index funds. I have a spreadsheet comparing six different platforms. I opened an account with one of them in 2021 and never put any money in. I keep thinking I'll start when I've worked out the right allocation. I'm still working it out.*
>
> PRIYA, 38, MARKETING DIRECTOR

PART THREE · WHY IT HAPPENS

# This is not a character flaw. It is a documented pattern.

THE RESEARCH

Sheena Iyengar's research at Columbia University demonstrated this pattern precisely. In her jam study, consumers presented with 24 choices were far less likely to purchase than those presented with 6. More importantly, the same effect shows up in pensions: a study of almost 800,000 employees found that every 10 extra funds on offer reduced the number of people joining their workplace scheme by around 2 percentage points. You are not unusual. You are displaying a documented human response to complexity.

Barry Schwartz's paradox of choice framework extends this: the more options available, the more anxious people become about their final selection, and the more likely they are to do nothing. The fear is not just of making the wrong choice. It is of the regret that would follow if you did. Intolerance of uncertainty research finds that individuals who score high on this trait tend to ruminate on unresolved decisions, which depletes the cognitive energy available for other tasks including work.

For Overthinkers, the research and comparison process also serves a protective function. As long as you are still researching, you have not made a decision that could go wrong. The process feels like progress without carrying the risk of an actual choice.

PART FOUR · COST

# The financial cost of this pattern is real.

Not as a judgement. As a number. These are the costs this pattern tends to produce when it runs unchecked for years or decades.

### Lost compounding

Someone who started investing £300 a month at 30 into a diversified portfolio with average 7% annual growth would have approximately £366,000 by 60. Starting at 40 with the same contribution and growth rate produces approximately £156,000. The difference is not the investment. It is the 10 years of inaction.

### The pension gap

The Overthinker who does not engage with their pension until they feel they fully understand it may be in their 40s before they meaningfully contribute. The employer matched contributions foregone in that period are significant.

### The cognitive cost

Research on decision fatigue shows that unresolved financial decisions do not disappear when you close the browser. They sit in your mental background, consuming cognitive resources. Acting, even imperfectly, frees that capacity.

PART FIVE · STRENGTHS

# You are not starting from nothing.

Every type has genuine strengths. Not as flattery. As the actual foundation progress is built on.

- When you do act on a financial decision you have researched, you typically do it well. The knowledge is real. It just needs a starting point rather than an endpoint.
- Your tendency to think carefully makes you less vulnerable to impulsive financial mistakes and to financial products that do not stand up to scrutiny.
- Your financial literacy means you can engage with the programme at a more sophisticated level than most. You will not be starting from scratch on concepts.

PART SIX · DIRECTION

# What progress actually looks like for you.

Progress for you is not becoming someone who makes fast decisions.
It is learning to act on good enough rather than waiting for perfect.

1

### Set a decision deadline

Pick a date two weeks from now. Whatever ISA platform, pension contribution, or savings product you have been researching, you will have chosen one and set it up by that date. Imperfect action now outperforms perfect action never.

2

### Reduce your options deliberately

Instead of comparing ten platforms, compare two. You are not looking for the best. You are looking for good enough to begin.

3

### Recognise that inaction has a cost

There is no neutral position. Every month you delay investing is a month of compounding growth that does not happen. Frame the risk of not acting alongside the risk of acting imperfectly.

4

### Go straight to Module 5

In Calm Money, Module 5, From Stability to Investing, is built for you specifically. It reduces the investment decision to its simplest components and gives you a framework for action rather than continued analysis.

PART SEVEN · BEGINNING

# You did not choose this pattern. But you can choose what happens next.

Reading a guide like this is not the same as acting on it. The point of the guide is not to make you feel seen, though I hope it has. The point is to make the next step obvious enough that you take it.

Calm Money is the programme that turns this reading of yourself into a structure you can actually use. Three pots. A debt cycle you can break. Savings that happen without you thinking about them. Investing that starts small and compounds. A community of people who are doing the same work.

The programme is not complicated. But it works because it addresses the pattern, not just the numbers.

## Begin the programme

Join Calm Money and start with the module built for Overthinkers.

**Join Calm Money →**

calmmoneycommunity.com



Peter Komolafe, Founder, Calm Money

Calm Money is financial education, not regulated financial advice. Nothing in this guide constitutes personalised advice under the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000. Always consider your own circumstances, and seek regulated advice where appropriate. The value of investments can go down as well as up, and you may get back less than you invest. © 2026 Conversation of Money Ltd.